

1973 ONWARDS

JAPANESE STYLE

Although Japanese designers Hanae Mori and Kenzo Takada were showing in Paris in the 1970s, it was Issey Miyake who brought the avant-garde movement to the fashion capital in 1973 with his radical approach to dress, a melding of art and science. Kansai Yamamoto made his Paris debut in 1975 with designs inspired by kimonos and kabuki costumes. In 1981 Rei Kawakubo and Yohji Yamamoto shocked fashion editors and buyers with oversized proportions, disregard for gender, and predominant use of black. Yamamoto was interested in purity of form and the interaction between body and fabric, while Kawakubo's focus for her Comme des Garçons label was on deconstruction, breaking down clothes and putting them together in unexpected ways. Kawakubo's protégé Junya Watanabe has forged his own look using techno materials and inventive construction.

ISSEY MIYAKE



One of the foremost textile innovators in fashion history, Issey Miyake established the Miyake Design Studio in Tokyo in 1970 to produce experimental garments. "I try not to fear radical things", he has said, and this is evident in the way he has pushed the boundaries of what clothes can be. Although his designs have sometimes appeared as sculptural objects, most of his retail range is practical. His *Pleats Please* line, for example, is a series of pleated tubes and flat shapes that come to life on the wearer and can be worn in numerous ways.

1973

Concentric circles
mimic samurai
archer's target

Cut as a full
circle of fabric

Wide-legged trousers
balance oversized
proportions above

Hat is
also scarf

Knit dress
falls over
body loosely

Shoes based
on lacquered
Japanese geta
(sandals)

1985

Cape cardigan
cut on circle
can be layered

Tonal hose and
unisex boots

Wearable art Although his clothes use fabrics and cuts that have resulted from sophisticated processes and experimental techniques, Miyake seeks to make his designs easy to wear. This 1985 ensemble based on simple, loose shapes is an example.

1989

Pockets at
side

Dress flares
out from
yoke

Angular
asymmetric band

Alternative vision Dubbed the poet of black, Yohji Yamamoto uses the occasional bright detail or piece for impact. The uneven band of orange in this dress creates visual dynamism.

Sculptural spectacle Kansai Yamamoto is considered the father of contemporary Japanese fashion. He interpreted traditional arts and dress in striking ways to create modern clothes, as seen in this outfit inspired by a samurai fire warden cape.

